Foreign aid is inconsistent due to the massive corruption within Myanmar. Recently, most of the significant aid to Myanmar comes from regional powers China and India, who continue to pursue lucrative concessions from the ruling junta.

RELIGION

The dominant religion throughout Myanmar is Theravada Buddhism. Most significant cultural aspects in Myanmar are tied to Buddhism. Approximately 89 percent of the people in Myanmar are Buddhist. Buddhism entered Myanmar in the 11th century during the reign of King Anawrahta. The *sangha* (monkhood) have always been deeply respected in society. The religion impacts the society, politics, and economy of Myanmar. Evidence of this is seen by the fact that nearly every village supports at least one monastery or monastic school. Buddhist pagodas dot the landscape throughout the entire country.

The Karen minority of southeast Myanmar practices Christianity, which constitutes four percent of the population. Islam practiced mainly in the Arakanese region also makes up four percent of the population. The remaining percentage is made up of mostly animist beliefs.

GOVERNMENT

Until September 1989, the country of Myanmar was known as Burma. The military junta justified the name change on the grounds that Burma was a vestige of British rule and the harsh colonial past. The United States and Great Britain continue to officially use the name Burma, and many academic journals and books still refer to the country as Burma. Numerous nations and many within the international community, including the United Nations, use Myanmar. In addition to the country name change, most names of cities and geographic locations were altered. For example, Rangoon became Yangon and the Irrawaddy River became the Ayeyarwaddy. Currently the junta calls itself the State Peace and Development Council (SPDC), and it rules Myanmar in an authoritarian fashion.

Myanmar is divided administratively into 14 states. Military commanders in the regions control the political system. Strict authority is maintained by